

ODISHA IN HIS SIGHT PM Modi on a roadshow in Puri where Sambit Patra is contesting, May 20

PATRA'S FAUX PAS

Unfortunately for Patra, his overconfident streak would vanish the same afternoon, when he chose to describe Lord Jagannath as a "Modi *bhakt*" at a press conference. The BJD was quick to pounce on this blasphemy, with Naveen taking to X to say, "Calling Mahaprabhu a *bhakt* of another human being is an insult to the Lord. This has hurt the sentiments and demeaned the faith of crores of Jagannath *bhakt*s and Odias across the world." Forced to apologise, Patra said he would fast for three days in front of the temple to seek forgiveness of the divine. Rubbing salt in his wound, Pandian told a news agency, "In this heat and dust, he should take care of himself and not faint."

Meanwhile, PM Modi, who once seemed to have cordial relations with Naveen, even praising him at a function a month earlier, surprised everyone when he lashed out at the CM at a campaign rally in Kandhamal district on May 11. "People of the state are unhappy with the CM because he cannot name the districts of the state and their capitals from a public platform without reading from a piece of paper," he said. "Can you trust him with your children's future?" A remark that came in for some ridicule since districts have headquarters, not capitals. At another rally the same day, alluding to Naveen's alleged incapacity to rule and allowing Pandian to fill in the gap, the PM said, "In Odisha, there is a SuperCM who lords over a democratically elected CM and MLAs." Naveen hit back in a video recording the same day, though not in response to Modi's allegation. "Remembering